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SUBMISSION TO THE PANEL ON SECURITY · LEGISLATIVE COUNCIL OF HONG KONG

Wang Fuk Court Fire Inquiry: the record is public, the answers are hard to find

A citizen-built, machine-readable companion to the Independent Committee's published record

To	Members of the Panel on Security, Legislative Council of Hong Kong
From	Wenyun Fu, Lucia Luo and Simon Wang (Wang Fuk Court Fire Report project)
Date	19 October 2026
Status	Final — 19 October 2026 · submitted by Lucia Luo
Subject	Accessibility of the inquiry record ahead of the Committee's final report, due by end of October 2026

1 · The original site: what it is, how it is built, where it falls short

Background. On **26 November 2025** a fire swept Wang Fuk Court in Tai Po — an eight-block Home Ownership Scheme estate of some 4,600 residents, built in 1983 and then undergoing renovation. It killed **168 people**, including firefighter Ho Wai-ho, displaced thousands, and was the city's worst fire since 1948. On **12 December 2025** the Chief Executive appointed an **Independent Committee**, chaired by Mr Justice David Lok, to establish the facts and make recommendations. Its **seven Terms of Reference** cover the cause of the fire, the renovation works and their supervision, the adequacy of existing laws and penalties, the emergency response, and related questions. Six rounds of public hearings ran from March to July 2026; the Committee's report is due to the Chief Executive by the end of October 2026.
Links: the Committee's site · mandate & Terms of Reference · notices and press releases · the document archive

The site we started from. The Committee publishes its evidentiary record at ic-wangfukcourtfire.gov.hk: a home/"About" page (mandate, membership, Terms of Reference), a **Documents** page holding all 243 files, a **Notices and Press Releases** page, and a separate Chinese mirror. The files are grouped by *working stage* — notices, then each round of hearings, witness statements, expert reports, closing submissions — because the design logic is the Committee's own schedule: what it did, in the order it did it. Everything is free to download; nothing is arranged by the questions the public actually asks.

Where it falls short — the starting point of our work:

- **Filed by schedule, not by question.** To answer one question you must open dozens of files filed under different weeks.

- **Keyword search, not answers.** Searching “collusion” returns about 30 hits — hearing transcripts in date order, each mentioning the word in passing; none of them tells you whether collusion occurred (Figure 2).
- **347 pages in 46 documents are scanned images** — no text, so no search can reach them at all.
- **No summaries, no citations, no map.** A reader cannot see what a document says without reading it, nor trace a claim to a page.
- **Two languages, two separate archives** — no cross-language search, so Chinese readers and English readers meet different silos of the same record.



Figure 1 · The starting point: the Committee’s own site, 243 PDFs filed in the order the work was done

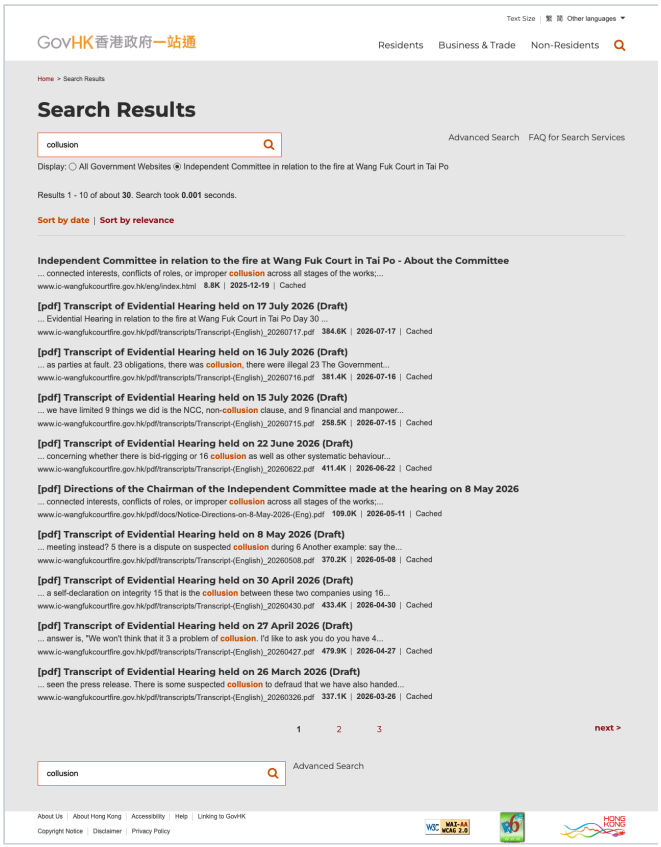


Figure 2 · The official search for “collusion”: about 30 hits — hearing transcripts in date order, none of them an answer

2 · What we built: a new site on top of the same record

We did not write a new report — we rebuilt the archive as a **new website**, free and bilingual, at wangfukcourtfirereport.simonsays.hk. Volunteers converted all 243 documents to text, read all ~1.9 million words, and re-organised everything by the Committee’s seven Terms of Reference:

243 PDFs crawled & audited · none missed → **Plain text** 6,377 pages · 347 OCR’d · 8,785 images → **7 Terms of Reference** every paragraph tagged by meaning, not keyword → **A new bilingual site** search · map · page citations · source PDFs

- **Converted** — PDF → text with page numbers; OCR for the 347 scanned pages; all 8,785 images extracted with their page references.

- **Read and tagged** — language models tagged every paragraph to the seven Terms of Reference by meaning, not keyword: bid-rigging material appears in **99 documents**, not the 11 a summary-level pass suggests (Figure 3).
- **Re-organised** — one page per document (summary, key points, contents, page citations, original PDF), one narrative per Term of Reference, plus an interactive document map and full-text search across all 243 files.
- **Published** — all documents · search · ToR narratives · 中文站 · our SCMP letter · coverage analysis · code & data

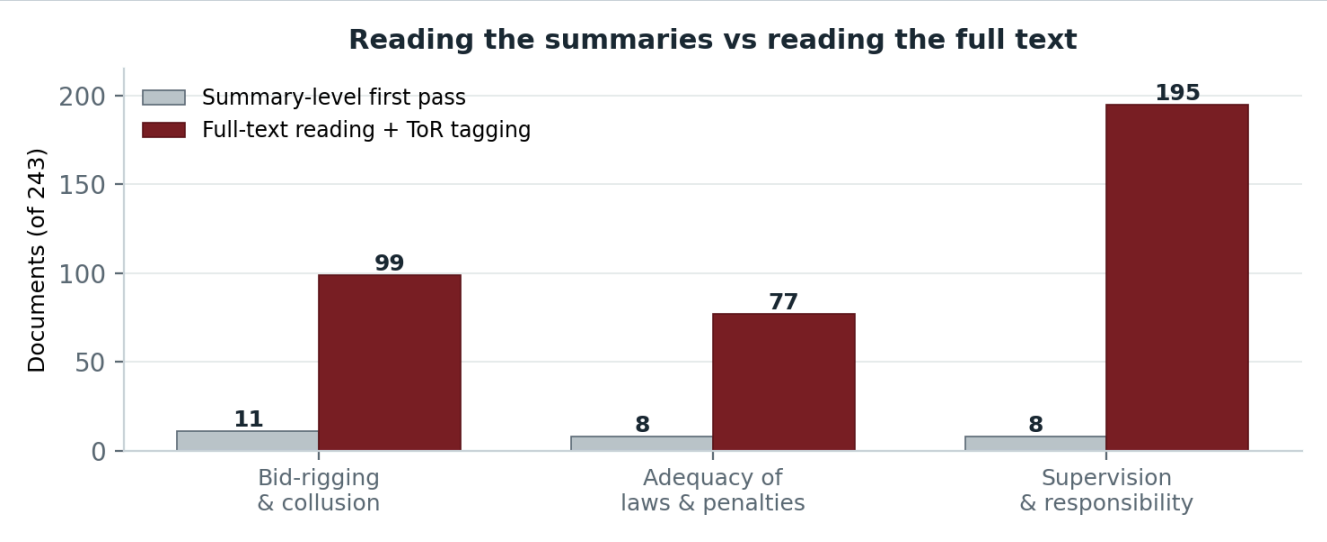


Figure 3 · Why full-text reading matters: documents found per Terms of Reference, summaries vs full text

What this gives a Member of the Panel — the value, stated plainly:

- **Verify in seconds.** Any figure quoted in debate can be checked against the page and the source PDF, before the meeting.
- **Prepare sharper questions.** See which contractors, departments and dates recur across the record, and where the evidence is thin.
- **Follow the report when it lands.** The Terms-of-Reference view is built for exactly the questions the Panel will be asked to oversee.
- **Brief staff and constituents** from a bilingual summary rather than a 6,377-page archive.

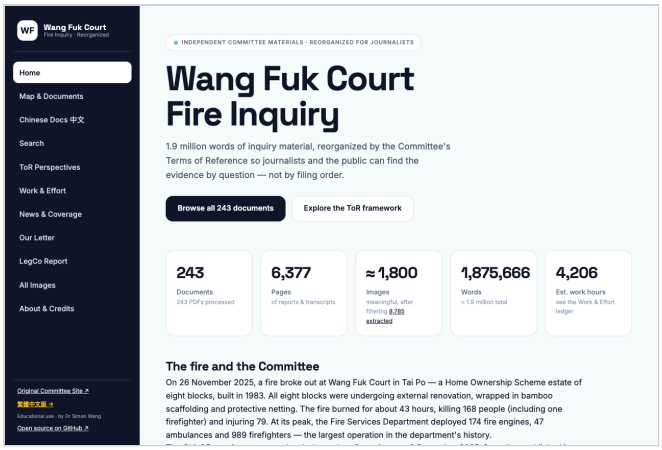


Figure 4 · Our home page: the same record re-organised around the seven questions the Committee was asked

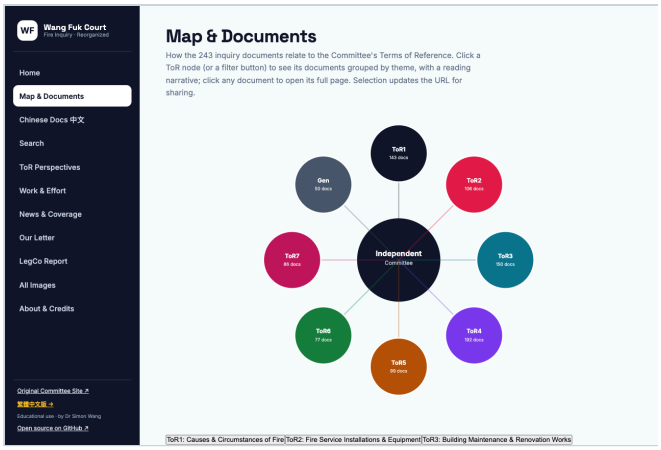


Figure 5 · Every document page: summary, key points, page-level citations and a link to the original PDF — the machinery that makes a claim checkable

3 · For journalists: the same record, a different job

Members want to verify and question; reporters on deadline want a story they can source. Both ask the same question — *what is the added value over the original site?* — and the answer is the same set of machinery, used differently:

- **Questions instead of filing order** — the seven Terms of Reference are the story structure.
- **Page-level citations** — every claim points to a page and the source PDF, so copy can be checked before publication.
- **Both languages** — quote in English or 繁體中文 from the same index.
- **Machine-readable output** — facts can be pulled into a newsroom database; we indexed 595 fire-day articles (26 Nov – 5 Dec 2025) this way.
- **Case 1 — the tender story.** The official search for “collusion” gives ~30 raw transcript hits and no answer (Figure 2); our Terms-of-Reference view gives **99 documents**, including a fire-service contractor that filed **85 shutdown-renewal notices without visiting the estate**, a renovation subcontract agreed **orally with no written contract**, and a contract attachment whose material-data folder was **empty** — none of which uses the words “bid-rigging” or “collusion”. See the ToR view →
- **Case 2 — the Chinese story.** Coverage of 宏福苑 runs **1,004 Chinese articles against 106 English** in the same eight weeks, yet no Chinese outlet can cite the inquiry record. Our Chinese pages give a quotable paragraph and a checkable PDF page. 中文站 → · coverage analysis →

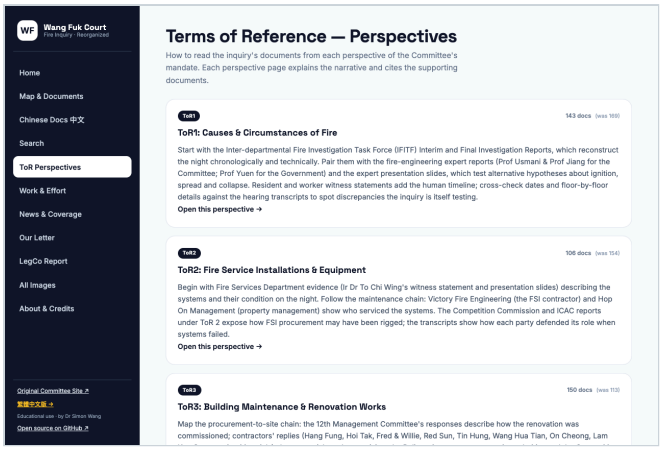


Figure 6 · ToR narratives: one page per question, in both languages — what a reporter or a member reads first

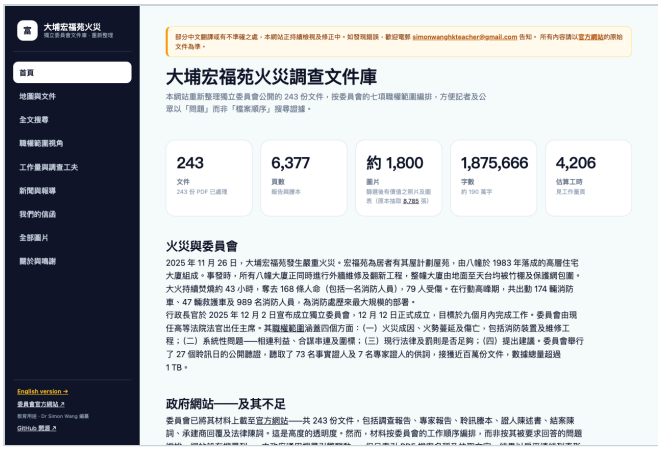


Figure 7 · The Chinese site: the same citations in 繁體中文, for the outlets and readers who work in Chinese

4 · Publishing public documents in an AI-ready age

Publishing documents to the public is something the Government does constantly — reports, papers, annexes, transcripts, statistics. The question we put to the Panel is simple: **when a document is published, is its format machine-readable and agent-friendly, or is it a traditional, image-based format that only a person can read?**

- **What we mean by machine-readable.** Not a PDF rendered as web pages, but a **structured file — XML or CSV — published through data.gov.hk**, the Government's own open-data portal, so that people and tools can both ingest it directly, and so that it sits alongside the statistics and datasets the public already uses.
- **The flagship example.** The 2026 Policy Address (policyaddress.gov.hk, checked 20 October 2026) is published as HTML chapters and a full PDF. We did not find a corresponding machine-readable dataset on data.gov.hk; if one exists, it should be linked from the publication itself.
- **The inquiry record is not even that.** A 6,377-page public record is published as PDFs alone, 347 pages of them as scanned images — the largest body of evidence in this affair is the least processable, and none of it is deposited as data.
- **Our position:** when a public body publishes a document, it should also deposit it as structured data **— XML or CSV through data.gov.hk** — at the point of publication: text not page images, headings and metadata not a flat filing order, stable links and page anchors so any answer can be traced. That deposit should be routine, not something volunteers reconstruct afterwards.
- **And reader-centred:** machine-readable is the floor; the real test is whether a document is arranged around its readers' questions, so that both people and machines can use it the first time.
- **Otherwise** an AI tool simply reproduces the search box's failure — fluent about the press release, silent about the record.

A note on how this was made: much of this work is AI-assisted — crawling, OCR, reading and tagging. That is precisely the point: if tools can do this in days, they can do it at source. Every claim above links to the original document, so readers should check us against it.

Links

Our live site (EN + 繁體中文)	All 243 documents
Full-text search	Seven Terms of Reference
中文站 Chinese site	Our letter in the SCMP
News coverage analysis	Official Committee site
This report, as a web page	This report, as a PDF
Previous version (20 Oct archive)	Source code & data

The full record — summaries, search, seven ToR narratives — is live at:

https://wangfukcourtfirereport.simonsays.hk/engagement/legcoReport.html

Search: https://wangfukcourtfirereport.simonsays.hk/ · News: https://wangfukcourtfirereport.simonsays.hk/news.html

Kept current; the QR code always opens the latest version.

Scan to open the live report page

7 · Signatories

▼ **Change log** — versions of this report (times in HKT, UTC+8)

- **19 Oct 2026, 19:57** — first final draft rendered as PDF (4 pages) for submission to the Panel.
- **19 Oct 2026, 20:05** — dedicated page created at `/engagement/legcoReport.html`; clickable links and QR added; status set to final.
- **19 Oct 2026, 20:24** — Chinese-language coverage findings added (宏福苑: 1,004 articles vs 106 English).
- **19 Oct 2026, 20:51** — journalist-facing section added; draft email to the Panel Secretariat published at `/engagement/legcoEmail.html`.
- **19 Oct 2026, 20:57 – 21:05** — three signatures embedded (transparent PNGs), student roles added, HKBU disclaimer added.
- **19 Oct 2026, 21:15** — site navigation renamed “Engagement” → “LegCo Report”; the old `legcoDraft` page removed.
- **19 Oct 2026, 21:32** — restructured into four sections with figures, a chart and a flow diagram; text cut to 55%.
- **20 Oct 2026, 20:18** — previous version archived at `/engagement/legcoReport_20_Oct.html`.
- **20 Oct 2026, 21:20** — “machine-readable” defined precisely as a structured **XML/CSV deposit on data.gov.hk**; Policy Address example re-framed accordingly.
- **20 Oct 2026, 20:20** — revision: background overview added (the fire, the Committee, its Terms of Reference, with links); original site’s structure and design logic described; critique kept as bullets; “new site” framing, figure-by-figure rationale, and a value list for Panel members; two journalist case studies with links; Policy Address example and the machine-readable position; AI-assisted note; this change log added; Figure 2 caption corrected (the official search returns ~30 hits, not “no results”).

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Simon Wang, PhD

Lecturer in English, Hong Kong Baptist University; co-author, SCMP letter, 19 August 2026

Disclaimer: The views expressed in this paper are those of the authors. They do not represent the Hong Kong Baptist University and have not been endorsed by the University.